But what if the moving company did the same to your cat, or, having sated your appetite for airplane gastronomy, what if you decided on teleportation for your own transatlantic travel? Would the cat or person who steps out of the receiving chamber be the same as the one who stepped into the teleporter? Personally, I think so. Again, since we have no relevant data, the best that I or anyone can do is speculate. But to my way of thinking, a living being whose constituent atoms and molecules are in exactly the same quantum state as mine *is* me. Even if the "original" me still existed after the "copy" had been made, I (we) would say without hesitation that each was me. We'd be of the same mind—literally—in asserting that neither would have priority over the other. Thoughts, memories, emotions, and judgments have a physical basis in the human body's atomic and molecular properties; an identical quantum state of these elementary constituents should entail an identical conscious being. As time went by, our experiences would cause us to differentiate, but I truly believe that henceforth there'd be two of me, not an original that was somehow "really" me and a copy that somehow wasn't.

In fact, I'm willing to be a bit looser. Our physical composition goes through numerous transformations all the time—some minor, some drastic—but we remain the same person. From the Häagen-Dazs that inundates the bloodstream with fat and sugar, to the MRI that flips the spin axes of various atomic nuclei in the brain, to heart transplants and liposuction, to the trillion atoms in the average human body that are replaced every millionth of a second, we undergo constant change, yet our personal identity remains unaffected. So, even if a teleported being did not match my physical state with perfect accuracy, it could very well be fully indistinguishable from me. In my book, it could very well *be* me.

Certainly, if you believe that there is more to life, and conscious life in particular, than its physical makeup, your standards for successful teleportation will be more stringent than mine. This tricky issue—to what extent is our personal identity tied to our physical being?—has been debated for years in a variety of guises without being answered to everyone's satisfaction. While I believe identity all resides in the physical, others disagree, and no one can claim to have the definitive answer.